South Korea

Language, Culture, and the Job Market

Pedro Henrique Peixoto Cardoso

October 2026

How the English Language Arrived

- **Missionaries:** Protestant missionaries introduced English alongside Western curricula(1885);
- **Post-WWII US Presence:** Expansion driven by US military and financial aid after WWII and the Korean War (1950–1953);
- **Social Status:** In the 70s and 80s, English mastery became a status symbol and a requirement for professional success;
- **The Konglish Phenomenon:** A linguistic fusion where English words are adapted to the Korean alphabet (Hangul).

Other Languages Spoken

- **Korean (Hangul):** The official language and the main symbol of national pride;
- **English:** The most widely studied foreign language, used in media, trade, and tech;
- **Historical Context:** Classical Chinese was used by the nobility before 1446. Japanese terms were used during the occupation (1910–1945) but later removed to preserve the Korean language.

Job Market

- **Corporate Culture:** Highly competitive, long hours, and dominated by *Chaebols* (family-owned conglomerates);
- **Social Challenges:** Women advanced in the workforce, but clashes with traditional patriarchy created the *Sampo Generation* (youth giving up dating, marriage, and children);
- **Demographic Crisis:** A low fertility rate (0.72) and an aging population pose major risks to the future workforce.

Brazilians in South Korea

- **Professional Expatriation:** Brazilian executives and professionals sent by multinational companies face challenges adapting to the corporate culture;
- **Tourism and Study:** A growing number of Brazilians travel to South Korea to learn Hangul and explore the country, heavily motivated by the global appeal of K-pop and K-dramas.

General Curiosities

- **Hangul Day (Oct 9):** A national holiday celebrating the alphabet created by King Sejong in 1443;
- **The Suneung Exam:** A brutal 8-hour university entrance exam that deeply impacts a student's future career and social standing;
- **Pop Tourism:** Landmarks like the Han River, Namsan Tower, and K-drama filming sets are massive global attractions;
- **Konglish Vocab:** English words adapted to Korean phonology (e.g., *handphone* for cell phone, *ice cream*).

Thank you for your attention!

References I

ARAÚJO, I. I. S.; MOREIRA, J. B. D.

Korean Wave: A influência do marketing de entretenimento na propagação da cultura sul-coreana.

Revista Multidisciplinar do Centro Universitário FIPMoc, Montes Claros, v. 37, n. 1, p. 86-121, 2024.

COELHO, A. R.

Expatriados: Expectativas, percepções e realidade. Um estudo sobre as experiências de expatriados brasileiros em países asiáticos.

Artigo (Mestrado Profissional em Administração) – FECAP, São Paulo, 2019.

MARINO, C. B. G.

O fenômeno Konglish na música popular coreana (K-Pop).

Monografia (Bacharelado em Tradução) – UFU, Uberlândia, 2020.

MONTEIRO, M. E. M.

Crise demográfica na Coreia do Sul: Causas e consequências da queda na taxa de natalidade para a economia sul-coreana.

TCC (Relações Internacionais) – PUC-Campinas, Campinas, 2025.